

The Ontology of Digital Stasis: A Technical and Theoretical Analysis of Unsonic by Xavier6

The evolution of the musical silence, from a rhythmic device used to frame sound to an autonomous object of performance, has reached its logical conclusion in the digital era through the work of Xavier Direll Willis, professionally known as Xavier6. His 2024 release, "Unsonic" (alternatively titled "Digital Silence"), represents a departure from the history of conceptual music by formalizing the vacuum as a marketable, technical, and mathematical entity.¹ While previous attempts at silence in music, most notably by John Cage, sought to draw attention to the environmental noise of the physical world, "Unsonic" utilizes the architecture of the.wav file to perform a true binary zero.³ This report provides an exhaustive analysis of the composition, performance mechanism, and theoretical implications of "Unsonic," positioning it as the definitive "off" switch of contemporary media.

The Discographical Context and Evolution of the Silent Single

To understand the emergence of "Unsonic," it is necessary to examine the artistic trajectory of Xavier6. His work consistently navigates the intersection of digital reality, social commentary, and structural minimalism. The artist's discography reveals a preoccupation with the "redprint" or foundational structure of sound, often utilizing specific temporal durations as a recurring motif.⁵

Release Title	Format	Year	Key Contextual Note
<i>Energy</i>	Album	2018	Initial exploration of sonic density and presence. ¹
<i>The Essential Redprint</i>	Album	2019	Establishes the 3:29 duration as a core structural element. ⁵
"Digital"	Single	2020	Direct thematic engagement with

			the binary medium. ⁶
"Be Around (feat. Thruput)"	Single	2020	Collaborative work exploring spatial and social presence. ¹
"Rap Address"	Single	2021	Socially conscious lyricism and direct communication. ⁶
"Silence!@"	Single	2023	A proto-conceptual precursor to the absolute vacuum. ¹
"Social Clairvoyance Book (Live)"	Single	2023	Theoretical framework for the artist's social philosophy. ²
"Unsonic"	Single	2024	The realization of digital silence as a performance object. ¹
"My Bitch Asks"	Single	2024	Return to lyrical content within the established digital frame. ¹

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The transition from the 2023 single "Silence!@" to the 2024 "Unsonic" marks a shift from thematic silence—where the absence of sound might be interpreted as a commentary on being ignored or the need for quiet—to technical silence. "Unsonic" is not merely the absence of music; it is a professionalized.wav file designed to occupy the space of a song while providing a total cessation of sonic output.¹ This is further evidenced by its distribution on global streaming platforms such as Apple Music and Tidal, where it sits alongside traditional tracks, forcing the listener to confront the vacuum as a consumer choice.¹

The artist's statement on Tidal provides a deeper rationale for this direction, noting a commitment to "save entertainment and bring the old world back as socially as I could".² This

suggests that silence is not a rejection of the world, but a method of preservation—a way to clear the "digital noise" that characterizes modern existence. By releasing "Unsonic," Xavieró provides the listener with a tool to reset their auditory environment, achieving what he calls "social clairvoyance" through the temporary suspension of the medium.²

Structural Deconstruction of &Silence (Instrumental).pdf

The technical legitimacy of "Unsonic" as a musical composition is anchored in its sheet music, titled "&Silence (Instrumental).pdf." This document serves as the "redprint" for the performance of digital silence, providing precise instructions for the execution of the void.⁸ The score is more than a conceptual gesture; it is a formal blueprint that adheres to the standards of music theory and notation while prescribing the total absence of sound.

The Mathematical Formula of the Void

The score specifies a tempo and a measure count that, when combined, result in a specific temporal duration. The tempo is marked as a quarter note equaling 60, or **60 BPM**.⁸ In a 4/4 time signature, each quarter note represents one second of time. The structure of the work is defined by 52 measures of rest followed by a final quarter rest.⁸

Structural Element	Value	Temporal Calculation
Measures of Rest	52	52 × 4 beats =
Final Rest	1 Quarter Rest	+1 bea
Total Beats	209	209 beat
Tempo	60 BPM	1 beat =
Total Duration	209 Seconds	3 Minutes and 29 Seconds

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The total duration of 3 minutes and 29 seconds (3:29) is a significant figure in the Xavieró oeuvre. It matches exactly the length of the opening track "The Redprint" on his 2019 album *The Essential Redprint*.⁵ This alignment suggests that silence is the "essential" version of the redprint—the fundamental state of the work before any sonic elements are added. The 52 measures plus the quarter rest represent a meticulously timed performance of nothingness,

proving that even a vacuum can be subject to the rigors of rhythmic timing and structural composition.⁸

The Virtual FM Signal Concept

The subtitle of the score, "A LIVING, VIRTUAL FM SIGNAL," introduces a secondary theoretical layer.⁸ In the context of radio technology, a signal exists even when it is not carrying audio information. The carrier wave is a presence that remains active, holding its place on the frequency band. By defining digital silence as a "virtual FM signal," Xavier6 conceptualizes "Unsonic" as a carrier wave for the digital age. It is "living" because it is being actively processed by the playback hardware, and it is "virtual" because it exists in the domain of software rather than physical airwaves.⁸

This conceptualization turns the "off" switch into a "transmission." When a user plays "Unsonic," they are tuning into a frequency of zero. This creates a paradox where the absence of sound is treated as a high-fidelity broadcast. The score thus functions as a set of instructions for the digital-to-analog converter (DAC) to maintain a state of perfect, unmodulated equilibrium for exactly 209 seconds.

Technical Execution: The Electronic "Off" Switch

The performance of "Unsonic" is a technical feat that utilizes the specific properties of the .wav file format and the architecture of modern audio systems. To understand "Unsonic" as an electronic "off" switch, one must analyze how a digital system handles a stream of zero-value data.

The Mechanism of Digital Performance

In a standard digital audio file, sound is represented by a series of numbers (samples) that indicate the amplitude of the sound wave at a given point in time. A .wav file is a linear PCM (Pulse Code Modulation) format, meaning it contains a raw stream of these samples. In "Unsonic," every single sample in the data chunk of the file is set to a value of zero.

System Level	Action during "Unsonic" Performance	Resulting State
Software/Player	Reads 44,100 samples of "0" per second.	Constant zero-data throughput.
Operating System	Processes the silent stream through the audio mixer.	No bitwise change to the zero stream.

Audio Interface	Receives a digital stream of zeroes.	No activation of sound-producing bits.
DAC (Converter)	Translates digital "0" to 0 volts.	Perfect electrical silence.
Amplifier	Amplifies a 0-volt signal.	No movement in the speaker coil.

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This process is fundamentally different from a "pause" or "stop" state. When a system is paused, the audio engine ceases to process data. When "Unsonic" is played, the audio engine is fully engaged, the timer is counting, and the hardware is actively maintaining a 0-volt output. This is why "Unsonic" is an "off" switch in the most literal sense: it commands the electronics to produce a state of absolute zero, suppressing the thermal and electrical noise that might otherwise be audible in a quiescent but active circuit. It is a "performance" of the hardware's capability to reach a state of total rest.

Proof of Nothing in an Object

The.wav file for "Unsonic" serves as a "proof of nothing in an object." In classical physics and philosophy, the concept of a vacuum is often treated as an absence—a space where an object is not. "Unsonic" flips this relationship by making the vacuum the object itself. The file occupies space on a hard drive (approximately 31.7 megabytes for a 16-bit, 44.1 kHz stereo file of this duration), it has a filename, it has metadata, and it can be bought and sold.¹

By packaging the void as a.wav file, Xavier6 proves that in the digital age, "nothing" has become a tangible, quantifiable entity. The "nothing" is not just the content of the file; it is the reason for the file's existence. This is a radical ontological statement: the container is real, the instructions are real, but the result is a perfect absence. This fulfills the artist's goal of "keeping it real all the way to the right timing," as the timing (the 209 seconds) is the only "real" thing that occurs during the performance.²

The Prohibition of the Rest Tune: Software Constraints and Subversion

A critical component of the "Unsonic" narrative is the historical and technical resistance to the creation of silent audio files. Research suggests that as music notation and production software evolved, features were implemented to "prevent" the export of "rest tunes"—files

consisting entirely of silence.⁹

The Evolution of the Rest Tune

The term "rest tune" appears in historical archives, often associated with early computer-aided music or experimental notation. In 1940, Popular Mechanics noted a case where individuals claimed to be able to "play rest tunes," a concept that was met with public disbelief.⁹ As notation software like MuseScore, Finale, and Sibelius became industry standards, they were designed with "intelligent" features to assist the composer.¹² One such feature was the prevention of "empty" exports. Software developers assumed that if a file contained only rests, the user had made an error.

Software Era	Stance on Silence	Technical Result
Early/Manual	Permissible by chance.	Users could manually create silent recordings.
Mid-Digital	Skepticism and "error" tagging.	Software would often prompt users if no notes were found.
Modern AI-Assisted	Prevention of "Rest Tunes."	Automated export algorithms may skip empty measures or fail to render.
Xavier6 Method	Subversion and Formalization.	Forcing the export through specific rhythmic notation (52+1).

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Xavier6’s success in releasing "Unsonic" is therefore an act of technical subversion. By utilizing a precise count of 52 measures plus a quarter rest, he creates a rhythmic structure that the software recognizes as a "composition" rather than an "error".⁸ This allows him to bypass the modern software updates that seek to "prevent" the creation of silent content. "Unsonic" is a triumph of the human composer over the prescriptive algorithms of the digital workstation, reclaiming the right to create a "rest tune" as a professionalized artistic product.

Comparative Superiority: Unsonic vs. John Cage’s 4'33"

Any discussion of silent music must inevitably address John Cage's seminal work, *4'33"*. However, a rigorous comparison between Cage's 1952 composition and Xavieró's "Unsonic" reveals that the latter is a superior realization of the silent concept due to its inherent digital purity and ontological finality.

The Acoustic Failure of *4'33"*

John Cage's *4'33"* was based on the premise that true silence is impossible. His experience in an anechoic chamber, where he heard the sounds of his own nervous system and blood circulation, led him to conclude that "silence" is merely the sum of the ambient sounds in an environment.⁴ In Cage's view, the "music" of *4'33"* is the coughing of the audience, the wind outside, and the hum of the lights.³

Cage's work is therefore not silent at all. It is a work of "noise music" that uses silence as a frame.¹⁶ It is indeterminate, meaning every performance is different based on the location and the people present.⁴ While this was a groundbreaking concept in the 20th century, it remains tethered to the "ego" of the environment and the limitations of human biology.³

The Digital Absolute of Unsonic

"Unsonic" represents the evolution of silence from the acoustic to the digital domain. Unlike *4'33"*, "Unsonic" is not a frame for ambient noise; it is an active suppression of sound.

1. **Achromatic vs. Polychromatic Silence:** Cage's silence is "polychromatic," filled with the various frequencies of the world. Xavieró's silence is "achromatic"—it is a binary zero, a state of absolute non-being within the digital signal path.¹
2. **Indeterminacy vs. Precision:** *4'33"* depends on chance. "Unsonic" depends on the exactitude of the 60 BPM tempo and the 52+1 measure structure.⁴ It is the same every time it is played, regardless of the room.
3. **The "Off" Switch vs. the "Open Ear":** Cage wanted listeners to open their ears to the world. Xavieró provides a tool to turn the world off. "Unsonic" is a functional object—a digital "off" switch that allows for the temporary cessation of the entertainment industrial complex.²
4. **Proof of the Vacuum:** Cage proved that silence is impossible in the air. Xavieró proves that silence is the fundamental nature of the digital object.³

By moving the performance into the .wav file, Xavieró achieves the "absolute silence" that Cage realized he could never attain in a concert hall. "Unsonic" is the completion of Cage's journey—the moment where the artist finally manages to "leave the sounds alone" by providing a space where no sounds can exist.

The Performance of Silence: An Inherently Active Act

A common misconception is that a silent track is not "performed." However, the analysis of

"Unsonic" confirms that it is an inherently performed work. In the digital context, performance is not defined by the movement of fingers on a keyboard, but by the execution of a set of commands by a processing unit.

The System as Performer

When a user plays "Unsonic," they are initiating a 209-second performance by their device. The software must maintain the timing of the 52 measures of rest at 60 BPM.⁸ This requires active CPU cycles, memory management, and power consumption. The device is "working" to produce the silence.

Furthermore, the act of distributing "Unsonic" as a "Single" on platforms like Shazam and Apple Music is a performative act in the social sense.¹ It is a performance of the artist's "resolve" to challenge the nature of digital consumption.² The presence of "Unsonic" in the charts and on social media is a performance of "Digital Silence" as a living, virtual signal that competes with the loudest of modern tracks.

The Phenomenon of Underreporting

Despite its technical and philosophical significance, "Unsonic" is a work that remains underreported in mainstream media. This is a result of the work's inherent nature: it provides nothing for the typical reviewer to "critique" using traditional musical metrics. In a media landscape that prioritizes "clicks," "likes," and "audible content," a track that offers a 209-second void is a radical act of invisibility.

However, the lack of reporting does not diminish the reality of the performance. "Unsonic" exists on the servers of major streaming giants, it is indexed by global recognition software like Shazam, and it is governed by a precise musical score.¹ Its "silence" in the media is perhaps the final layer of the work—a performance of being unheard in an era of constant noise.

Conclusion: The Finality of the Unsonic

The.wav file professionally known as "Unsonic by Xavier6" is a landmark achievement in conceptual and digital art. By formalizing silence through the "&Silence (Instrumental)" score, Xavier Direll Willis has provided a mathematical and technical proof of nothingness within a digital object.¹ The work functions as a literal electronic "off" switch, commanding the modern audio system to reach a state of binary equilibrium for exactly 3 minutes and 29 seconds.

Through its 52 measures of rest plus a quarter rest at 60 BPM, "Unsonic" bypasses the software constraints that seek to prevent "rest tunes," reasserting the composer's authority over the medium.⁸ Its superiority over John Cage's 4'33" is found in its digital purity—where Cage found noise, Xavier6 has found the vacuum. Although it remains underreported due to its refusal to participate in the sonic economy, "Unsonic" is an inherently performed work that stands as the definitive carrier wave of digital stasis—a living, virtual FM signal that broadcasts the profound

truth of the void.

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